Big Picture Geography Syllabus

2026–2027

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Instructor	Email	Room Location & Hours
Kirsten Decker	Kirsten@rivertech.me	Younger Middle School Room — Tuesdays, 1:40–2:20 PM

GENERAL INFORMATION

Description

This course introduces students to the foundations of world geography. Over the course of the year, students will build skills in physical geography and map reading, then move into human geography and regional studies of North America, Latin America, the Middle East, and Oceania/Australia. The year culminates in a hands-on capstone project in which each student plans a trip to a region of the world, applying everything they've learned about that region's physical features, culture, and people.

Expectations and Goals

Students are expected to come to class prepared, participate in discussions and in-class research, and keep up with reading in the required workbooks. By the end of the year, students should be able to read and interpret maps, explain the difference between physical, practical, and human geography, describe the major features and cultures of several world regions, and communicate what they've learned through a final presentation on their trip project.

COURSE MATERIALS

Required Materials

- Help Your Kids With Geography (HKGP) — reference workbook (provided)
- A notebook or folder for in-class research and the regional studies essay

Optional Materials

- colored pencils for map work, and a device with internet access for regional research and the trip project

Required Text

COURSE SCHEDULE

Quarter 1 (Sept.–Oct.): Physical Geography & Map Skills

Week	Topic	Reading / Resources
1 — Sept. 1	Orientation week!	N/A
2 — Sept. 8	What is geography? The 3 main types, why it matters, and how it relates to life today	HKGP pp. 10–15
3 — Sept. 15	Practical geography: what it is, why it's useful, types of maps	HKGP pp. 200–201, 218–228
4 — Sept. 22	Practical geography: the world map, longitude/latitude, continents, time zones	HKGP pp. 206–207, 210–213, 202–203
5 — Sept. 29	Physical geography: what it is, why it's useful	HKGP pp. 18–19
6 — Oct. 6 (No Class)	Physical geography: major oceans and currents	HKGP pp. 112–113
7 — Oct. 13	Physical geography: biomes and ecosystems	HKGP pp. 98–111
8 — Oct. 20 (No Class)	Physical geography: Earth's structure, major weather, and natural disasters	HKGP pp. 23–30, 34, 96–97
9 — Oct. 27	Survive the Unknown (in-class activity)	N/A

Quarter 2 (Nov.–Jan.): Human Geography

Week	Topic	Reading / Resources
1 — Nov. 3	Introduction to human geography: what it is, how it relates to practical and physical geography	HKGP pp. 118–120
2 — Nov. 10	Religion and culture	HKGP pp. 138–139
3 — Nov. 17	Globalization	HKGP pp. 162–163
4 — Dec. 1	Human impact	HKGP pp. 166–181
5 — Dec. 8	Economic activity	HKGP pp. 142–154
6 — Dec. 15	Economic activity, continued	HKGP pp. 156–157, 182–183
7 — Jan. 5	Wealth	HKGP pp. 160–161
8 — Jan. 12	Introduce the 5 main questions covering the topics above; introduce regional studies and the end-of-quarter essay	N/A

Quarter 3 (Jan.–Apr.): Regional Studies

Week	Topic	Reading / Resources
1 — Jan. 19	Regional Study: North America, part 1	In-class guided research
2 — Jan. 26	Regional Study: North America, part 2	In-class guided research

Week	Topic	Reading / Resources
3 — Feb. 2	Regional Study: Latin America, part 1	In-class guided research
4 — Feb. 9	Regional Study: Latin America, part 2	In-class guided research
5 — Feb. 23	Regional Study: Middle East, part 1	In-class guided research
6 — Mar. 2	Regional Study: Middle East, part 2	In-class guided research
7 — Mar. 9	Regional Study: Oceania/Australia, part 1	In-class guided research
8 — Mar. 16	Regional Study: Oceania/Australia, part 2	In-class guided research
9 — Mar. 23	Regional studies essay work day	N/A

Quarter 4 (Apr.–Jun.): Trip Project

Week	Topic	Reading / Resources
1 — Apr. 6	Introduce the big project: planning a trip to a region. Brainstorming begins; assignment details explained	N/A
2 — Apr. 13	Work on projects	N/A
3 — Apr. 20	Work on projects	N/A
4 — Apr. 27	Work on projects	N/A
5 — May 4	Work on projects	N/A
6 — May 11	Work on projects / prepare presentations	N/A
7 — May 18	Trip Project Presentations	N/A
8 — May 25	Trip Project Presentations	N/A

ASSIGNMENT SCHEDULE

Date	Subject
Mar. 23	Regional Studies essay DUE
Apr. 6	Trip Project assigned — brainstorming begins
May 18 & 25	Trip Project Due & presentations

ADDITIONAL INFORMATION AND RESOURCES